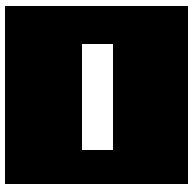




PHOTO BY **HARDIK CHHABRA**



S IT OVER? It's a question that's top of mind for IndiGo flyers after a massive disruption in operations early December. The trigger was a government rule mandating more rest hours for pilots for which the airline was unprepared—it report-

edly failed to hire enough, resulting in cancellation of hundreds of flights and forcing the government to give it an extension for a couple of months.

There is some semblance of stability for now, but what after February 10, when the new deadline for complying with the rules—termed Flight Duty Time Limitation (FDTL)—ends?

Experts see more pain in 2026 as hiring pilots in large number can take months. The airline is expected to need around 900 pilots, mainly commanders, by the end of 2026, due to planned expansion and the FDTL rules. The immediate requirement is 200. The Director General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) has already ordered the carrier to cut 10% of its domestic flights. This means 100-200 fewer flights per day.

The new year will be marked by capacity constraints on metro routes and high airfares. IndiGo accounts for 65% of the domestic aviation market.

What could bring further trouble is the possibility of stringent penal action by the government. Civil Aviation Minister Ram Mohan Naidu has blamed the IndiGo management for the crisis, and a four-member committee of officials is investigating the matter. "Any kind of action required based on the incompetence of

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Extension of deadline for new safety rules has brought only short-term relief for the airline and passengers. With no easy fix, a permanent solution will need a lot more work and time

BY **RICHA SHARMA**

THE FLIGHT PATH

▶ **THE GOVERNMENT INTRODUCED NEW DUTY RULES IN JANUARY 2024. THESE WERE TO BE ADOPTED IN TWO PHASES, BY JUNE AND NOVEMBER THIS YEAR**

▶ **OTHER BIG CARRIERS COMPLIED, BUT INDIGO SAID IT WAS UNABLE TO DO SO DUE TO REQUIREMENT OF ADDITIONAL PILOTS**

▶ **IT HAD TO CANCEL HUNDREDS OF FLIGHTS DUE TO PILOT SHORTAGE**

▶ **THE GOVERNMENT WAS FORCED TO GIVE IT AN EXTENSION TILL FEBRUARY 10**

▶ **BUT HIRING NEW PILOTS TAKES MONTHS; EVEN WITH REDUCED FLIGHTS, IT WOULD NOT BE ABLE TO RESUME NORMAL OPERATIONS ANY TIME SOON, SAY EXPERTS**

